IIIF in Switzerland

A Landscape of Compatible Platforms and Engaged Institutions

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Summary

In 2019, a white paper published at the Haute école de gestion de Genève as part of the TICKS (Towards IIIF-Compliance Knowledge in Switzerland, 2018-2019) project set out suggested measures for deploying the International Image Interoperability Framework (IIIF) in Swiss cultural heritage institutions. Since then, the question has shifted from whether IIIF has a place in Switzerland to where it is already in use, and at which level of the specifications. This short report offers a panorama of Swiss platforms that publish IIIF resources meeting explicit compatibility criteria, together with the Swiss members of the IIIF Consortium (IIIF-C). Implementation guidance is deliberately out of scope, although pointers to further resources are provided.

Twenty-three platforms are surveyed, operated by national and cantonal libraries, archives, universities, research infrastructures, museums and foundations. Seventeen of them publish Presentation API resources that meet the criteria, and six are included for their Image API services alone. Version 3.0 of the Presentation API is now used by seven platforms, while ten, among them the long-standing library portals that pioneered IIIF in Switzerland, still rely on version 2.x. Taken together, the platforms for which a figure could be estimated publish well over 600,000 Manifests.

The panorama also highlights recurring issues. Few platforms advertise a top-level Collection, only six are listed in the IIIF community guide *Finding IIIF Resources*, and some IIIF resources remain hidden from users, reachable only through a bespoke API. Beyond the two core specifications, other IIIF APIs and services, such as Content Search or Physical Dimensions, are implemented by only a handful of platforms. Shared university infrastructures increasingly allow research projects to publish IIIF resources without running their own servers. As of October 2026, two organisations based in Switzerland are IIIF-C members: DaSCH, the Swiss National Data and Service Center for the Humanities, and the University of Bern.

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Versioning and citation

This report is intended to be updated over time. A new major version (2.0, 3.0, and so on) is published for each new survey round, carried out when the landscape has changed enough to warrant it, whether after one year or several, while minor versions (1.1, 1.2, and so on) bring corrections and additions in between. The all-versions DOI always resolves to the latest version. When referring to specific figures, please cite the version you consulted.

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1 Introduction

IIIF is a set of open application programming interfaces (APIs) that standardise how image-based resources, that is still images but also audiovisual materials and now 3D content, are delivered, described and annotated on the web.[1] From the outset, it was conceived as both a community and a technology approach to web-based images [10]. Its two core specifications are the *Image API*, which delivers pixels (regions, sizes, rotations, formats) through a predictable URL syntax, and the *Presentation API*, which describes how a digital object should be presented to a viewer by means of a JSON-LD document called a *Manifest*. Manifests can in turn be grouped into *Collections*, which allow a whole platform or a subset of it to be browsed and harvested. Further specifications cover access control, search within content, change discovery and the sharing of a particular view of a resource.

Compatible IIIF clients (viewers, players) can display IIIF-compatible content regardless of where it is published. IIIF thus allows institutions to keep their own repositories while letting users compare, annotate and reuse objects across collections and borders. In practice, support for individual features still varies from one client to another, which is why the community documents client support and good practices through a matrix and a cookbook of recipes.[2] This distributed model, in which resources remain with their holders yet can be combined freely by compatible clients, is precisely where the epistemological value of IIIF lies [11]. That promise of interoperability was the starting point of the 2019 white paper [4], which addressed Swiss heritage institutions considering adoption. The present report takes stock of what has since become visible on the ground.

Taking stock of IIIF in a country is not only a matter of counting platforms; it also means asking who carries the framework and how. IIIF is carried by its community, in which two levels can be distinguished. The *IIIF community* at large is the open, self-organising network of practitioners, developers, researchers and institutions who meet in community and technical specification groups, test and implement the specifications, and reach decisions by consensus. Anyone can take part, whether or not their institution pays a membership fee. In my doctoral work, I examined such community practices, that is, the ways in which organisations, individuals and technical apparatuses engage with and contribute to the consensus-making processes around Linked Open Usable Data standards, with the IIIF and Linked Art communities as empirical cases [7]. A survey conducted as part of that work characterised who makes up these two communities and how their members participate [5]. The *IIIF Consortium* (IIIF-C) is the steering body: its member institutions fund staff, events and infrastructure and provide the governance that ensures IIIF can exist in the long term. Section 5 focuses on the Swiss members of IIIF-C.

[1] https://iiif.io/api/

[2] https://iiif.io/api/cookbook/

2 What Has Changed Since 2019

The 2019 white paper was written when the stable IIIF specifications were the Image and Presentation APIs at version 2.1, the Authentication API 1.0 and the Search API 1.0.[3] Alpha drafts of version 3.0 had been circulating since April 2018, but no 3.0 specification was final. Since then, the framework has grown considerably:

Date	Publication
June 2020	Image API 3.0 and Presentation API 3.0, the latter adding first-class support for audio and video
June 2021	Change Discovery API 1.0, based on W3C Activity Streams,[4] for harvesting and synchronising IIIF resources at scale
March 2022	Content State API 1.0, for sharing a specific view of a resource between applications
November 2022	Content Search API 2.0, aligned with Presentation API 3.0
May 2023	Georeference extension, alongside the navPlace and Text Granularity extensions to the Presentation API
July 2023	Authorization Flow API 2.0, replacing the Authentication API 1.0
June 2026	Presentation API 4.0 alpha draft, introducing Scenes for 3D content [2]
In progress	Presentation API 4.0 stable release

IIIF therefore now counts six stable API specifications and several Presentation API extensions, against four specifications in 2019. Two changes matter especially for this report. First, the Authorization Flow API makes it possible to publish Manifests for digital objects whose content is restricted, with compatible clients informing users about how to gain access; a Manifest can thus be interoperable even when the resources it describes, whether images, audio or video, are not openly accessible. Second, the Change Discovery API offers a standard way to make an entire platform discoverable and harvestable by aggregators, rather than only one object at a time. Top-level Collections provide a more minimal entry point, which is useful but often not very intuitive, since it may require going through a very long table of contents to reach a given Manifest. The Content State API is relevant too, although its uptake rests mainly with IIIF clients, which need to implement the corresponding functionalities, such as sharing, bookmarking or reopening a specific view of a resource.

In parallel, the scope of IIIF adoption has shifted. In 2019, IIIF in Switzerland was largely a library affair carried by the manuscript and rare book portals. It now spans archives, research infrastructures and museums, as Table 1 shows.

[3] Dates are taken from the change logs of each specification.

[4] https://www.w3.org/TR/activitystreams-core/

3 Scope and Criteria

A platform is included in this panorama when it meets the following criteria:

C1 Compatibility. For platforms publishing Presentation API resources, sampled Manifests pass the official IIIF Presentation API Validator[5] against the version they declare. When the validator only returns warnings, the Manifest must at least open in a viewer that is *not* operated by the institution itself, such as Mirador or the Universal Viewer. What counts is that the Manifest is understood by an external client, not that the content itself is displayed: where access is governed by the Authorization Flow API, a viewer implementing that specification will present the relevant access information instead of the images. At the time of writing, I have not encountered any Swiss institution implementing the Authorization Flow API; the criterion is nevertheless kept in this form so that such implementations can be accounted for in future versions. Platforms that expose only the Image API are included when an image request following the Image API URL syntax returns the expected image, and when the image information document (`info.json`) can be loaded in a deep zoom viewer not operated by the institution.

C2 Public reach. The platform is operated by, or closely associated with, a public service or research mission: public libraries and archives, universities and research infrastructures, or museums and foundations that make their collections openly accessible.

C3 Swiss anchoring. The operator is based in Switzerland, or the platform is primarily devoted to Swiss holdings.

The panorama is not exhaustive. IIIF adoption is largely community driven and distributed. A registry exists for platforms that implement the Change Discovery API,[6] but it has not yet been widely taken up, even though registering there is an important step that institutions should take. As a result, platforms that do not explicitly state that they are IIIF-compatible are hard to find, and some may well have been missed. Readers are welcome to point out omissions for future versions. Moreover, many Swiss institutions use IIIF internally, within digital asset management systems, or on platforms that did not meet criterion C1 at the time of writing. Commercial services and vendor demonstrators are left out on purpose (see the Statement of Competing Interests).

[5] https://presentation-validator.iiif.io/
[6] https://registry.iiif.io/

4 Platforms

Table 1 lists the platforms retained, in alphabetical order. For each, it records the operator, the type of content, the IIIF API versions observed, whether a top-level IIIF Collection is published, the number of Manifests where known, and whether the platform appears in *Finding IIIF Resources*,[7] a community guide maintained by IIIF-C that explains how to locate Manifests on a given website. The survey focuses mainly on the two core specifications, the Image and Presentation APIs. Support for the other IIIF APIs is not recorded systematically, although notable cases are mentioned below.

Libraries and consortial portals remain the backbone of IIIF in Switzerland. The longest-standing platforms, **e-codices**, **e-rara**, **e-manuscripta**, **e-newspaperarchives.ch**[8] and **Fragmentarium**, together publish several hundred thousand Manifests but still rely on version 2.x of the Image and Presentation APIs, which remain fully usable in current viewers but do not benefit from the features introduced with version 3.0. They are joined by **ZentralGut**, the platform for the cultural heritage of Central Switzerland, **Plume** at the EPFL Library and **BodmerLab** at the University of Geneva, all three also in version 2.x.

Archives, which were largely absent from the IIIF landscape in 2019, are now represented by the Swiss Federal Archives, whose **Online Access to the Federal Archives** portal and edition of the **Minutes of the Federal Council** both publish Presentation API 3.0 resources and also support the IIIF Content Search API, allowing full-text search directly from a compatible viewer [8]. Version 3.0 is also used by research and heritage portals such as **PARC**, the Portal for African Research Collections at the University of Basel, and the **Swiss Performing Arts Platform** of the Swiss Archive of the Performing Arts (SAPA).

Museums form the most recent and fastest growing group. The digital collection of the **SKKG** in Winterthur publishes more than 60,000 Manifests in version 3.0, while the **Kunsthaus Zürich** and ZentralGut even expose the Physical Dimensions service in their image information, a rarely implemented IIIF service that lets a client display a ruler or render an object at its physical scale.[9] The Musée d'art et d'histoire de Genève (MAH) also publishes IIIF resources, but these are very difficult to find from its own website;[10] they are therefore counted here as part of Hedera, through which they are published (see below).

Six platforms currently qualify through their Image API services alone: the **Bibliothèque numérique Photo Elysée**, **Images of Switzerland Online (BSO)**, the **DaSCH Service Platform**, the **Kunstmuseum Basel**, **Le Temps Archives** and **Books as Data**. Their images can already be opened in compatible IIIF image viewers;[11] publishing valid Manifests on top of these services would make them reusable, with their metadata and structure, in compatible IIIF clients. Books as Data, a collaboration between the University Library Basel, the Zentralbibliothek Zürich, the Zentral- und Hochschulbibliothek Luzern and the University of Bern, is a special case: its images are served through the Image API 3.0 and meet criterion C1, whereas its Manifests still contain elements that do not pass the Presentation API Validator. It would fully qualify once these issues are resolved. Books as Data has also implemented the IIIF Content Search API, although this is difficult to test beyond its own infrastructure.

Visual Contagions and BodmerLab illustrate another configuration: their IIIF resources are not published by the projects themselves but through **Hedera**, the research data platform of the University of Geneva's e-Research service [1],[12] which serves images through the Image API 3.0 and exposes one Presentation API 3.0 Collection per research project. **Visual Contagions** alone accounts for more than 100,000 Manifests. Hedera is therefore listed in Table 1 both as a platform

[7] https://guides.iiif.io/finding_resources/
[8] https://veridiansoftware.com/knowledge-base/implementation-of-iiif-for-the-swiss-national-library
[9] https://iiif.io/api/annex/services/#physical-dimensions
[10] https://www.mahmah.ch/
[11] https://iiif.github.io/awesome-iiif/#image-viewers-image-api-only
[12] https://www.unige.ch/eresearch/en/services/hedera/what-iiif

in its own right, covering projects such as that of the MAH, and through Visual Contagions and BodmerLab, whose Manifests are counted separately. Such shared university infrastructures, like the IIIF service of the University of Bern described in Section 5, allow research projects and partner institutions to publish interoperable resources without operating their own servers.

Discoverability lags behind adoption. **Memobase**, the aggregation platform of Memoriav, the national competence centre for Switzerland's audiovisual heritage, offers a telling example: it provides IIIF resources for still images, but these are not advertised in its user interface. They can only be reached by adapting record URLs or through the Memobase API,[13] where Manifests are generated by a dedicated post-processing service.[14] Memobase can also ingest existing IIIF Manifests from its partner institutions, which makes publishing valid Manifests all the more worthwhile for audiovisual heritage holders. More generally, only six of the twenty-three platforms are listed in the IIIF community guide, and few advertise a top-level Collection. Registering Swiss platforms there, and exposing Manifest and Collection links clearly, would make digital objects from Swiss institutions easier to find, aggregate and reuse.

[13] https://api.memobase.ch/; see also https://memobase.ch/de/info-memobase/mitmachen
[14] https://ub-basel.atlassian.net/wiki/spaces/MD/pages/618627505/Post-Processing

Table 1: Swiss platforms publishing IIIF resources that meet the criteria of Section 3, in alphabetical order. Version numbers are those declared by the platforms' Manifests and image services. Notes specific to a cell appear in italics within it; general notes follow the table.

Platform	Operator	Content	Image API	Presentation API	Top-level Collection	Manifests[a]	Guide[b]
Bibliothèque numérique Photo Elysée `photobookselysee.ch`	Photo Elysée, Lausanne, with EPFL	Museum catalogues and publications	2.1	Image API only	n/a	n/a	no
BodmerLab `bodmerlab.unige.ch`	University of Geneva, Fondation Martin Bodmer	Manuscripts and printed books	2.1	2.x *Via Hedera; Collection in 3.0, Manifests in 2.x.*	yes	> 1,000	✓
Books as Data `books-as-data.ch`	UB Basel, ZB Zürich, ZHB Luzern, University of Bern	Digitised books as research data	3.0	3.0 (not yet valid) *Some Manifests fail validation. Also implements Content Search; hard to test externally.*	n/k	n/a	no
DaSCH Service Platform (DSP) `app.dasch.swiss`	DaSCH	Humanities research data	3.0	Image API only	n/a	n/a	no
e-codices `e-codices.ch`	University of Fribourg	Medieval and early modern manuscripts	2.1	2.x	yes *Groups all collections. Temporarily unavailable.*	> 3,000	✓
e-manuscripta `e-manuscripta.ch`	Zentralbibliothek Zürich and partner institutions	Manuscripts and archival material	2.1	2.x *Full-image @id values are not Image API URLs.*	yes	≈ 200,000	✓
e-newspaperarchives.ch `e-newspaperarchives.ch`	Swiss National Library	Swiss newspapers and periodicals	2.1	2.1	per title in the public domain *One Collection per title.*	n/k	no
e-rara `e-rara.ch`	ETH Library and partner libraries	Printed books	2.1	2.x *Full-image @id values are not Image API URLs.*	yes	≈ 150,000	✓
Fragmentarium `fragmentarium.ms`	Fragmentarium, Fribourg	Medieval manuscript fragments	2.1	2.x	yes	> 8,000	✓
Hedera `hedera.unige.ch`	University of Geneva, e-Research	Research and cultural heritage data from multiple academic projects or partner institutions	3.0	3.0	per project *One Collection per project.*	> 18,000 *Excludes BodmerLab and Visual Contagions.*	no
Images of Switzerland Online (BSO) `bilder-der-schweiz.online`	University of Zurich, SARI	Historical views and prints of Switzerland	2.1	Image API only	n/a	n/a	no
Kunsthaus Zürich `digital.kunsthaus.ch`	Zürcher Kunstgesellschaft	Art collection	2.1 *Physical Dimensions service.*	2.x	n/k	n/k	no
Kunstmuseum Basel[c] `iiif.kumu.swiss`	Kunstmuseum Basel	Art collection	3.0	Image API only	n/a	n/a	no
Le Temps Archives `letempsarchives.ch`	Le Temps, with EPFL and libraries	*Journal de Genève*, *Gazette de Lausanne*, *Le Nouveau Quotidien*	2.1	Image API only	n/a	n/a	no

Continued on next page

Table 1, continued

Platform	Operator	Content	Image API	Presentation API	Top-level Collection	Manifests[a]	Guide[b]
Memobase memobase.ch	Memoriav	Swiss audiovisual heritage	2.1	2.x *Still images only; hidden in the UI.*	n/k	n/k	no
Minutes of the Federal Council chgov.bar.admin.ch	Swiss Federal Archives (SFA)	Minutes of the Federal Council, 1848 to 1975	2.1	3.0 *Implements the Content Search API.*	yes	> 10,000	no
Online Access to the Federal Archives recherche.bar.admin.ch	Swiss Federal Archives (SFA)	Federal archival records	2.1	3.0 *Only for unrestricted digitised records.* *Manifest links trigger a download instead of opening in the browser.* *Implements the Content Search API.*	n/k	n/k	no
PARC parc-portal.org	University of Basel	Portal for African Research Collections	3.0	3.0	n/k	> 95,000	no
Plume plume.epfl.ch	EPFL Library	Rare books	2.1 *Thumbnails not via the Image API.*	2.x	n/k	≈ 300	✓
SKKG, Digital Collection digital.skkg.ch	Stiftung für Kunst, Kultur und Geschichte (SKKG), Winterthur	Art, culture and history collection	3.0	3.0	n/k	> 60,000	no
Swiss Performing Arts Platform performing-arts.ch	SAPA, Swiss Archive of the Performing Arts	Theatre and dance heritage	3.0	3.0	n/k	n/k	no
Visual Contagions visualcontagions.unige.ch	University of Geneva, via Hedera	Global circulation of images in printed media	3.0	3.0	yes *First 2,000 Manifests only.*	> 100,000	no
ZentralGut zentralgut.ch	ZHB Luzern	Cultural heritage of Central Switzerland	2.1 *Physical Dimensions service.*	2.x	n/k	> 5,000 *Based on the number of image-based resources.*	no

[a] Number of Manifests published, as of October 2026. Figures are deliberately rounded, even where an exact count was available: "> " gives a lower bound and "≈" an approximation, as counts change continuously and were obtained by different means, such as top-level Collections, search filters or platform statistics.
[b] Listed in *Finding IIIF Resources* as of October 2026.
[c] Homepage shows a different IIIF image at each refresh.
n/a: not applicable; n/k: not known.

5 Swiss Members of the IIIF Consortium

As of October 2026, two Swiss organisations are members of IIIF-C.[15]

DaSCH, Swiss National Data and Service Center for the Humanities
DaSCH is listed as a founding member of IIIF-C. This membership goes back to the Digital Humanities Lab (DHLab) of the University of Basel, which joined the consortium in January 2017.[16] The two organisations are closely intertwined: both are tied to the University of Basel, and many of the people involved have worked at both the DHLab and DaSCH. DaSCH develops SIPI, an open source IIIF image server [9],[17] and images on its Service Platform are delivered through SIPI via the Image API. In recent years, DaSCH has also been closely involved in both the IIIF 3D Community and Technical Specification Groups [6], and in 2023 it hosted an event titled "DaSCHCon on IIIF, 3D & Interoperability".

University of Bern
The University of Bern joined IIIF-C as an associate member at the beginning of 2026, with its University Library carrying the membership.[18] The University Library runs a centrally hosted, long-term IIIF service for researchers, combining an image server with a frontend through which images and metadata can be uploaded.[19] The service offers the Image and Presentation APIs in versions 2.1 and 3.0 and is used by projects such as hallerNet, Herbarium Bernense and the Gotthelf edition [3].

The École polytechnique fédérale de Lausanne (EPFL) was formerly a member of the consortium but no longer is. Beyond IIIF-C, Swiss practitioners continue to take part in the open IIIF community groups and committees.

[15] https://iiif.io/community/consortium/members/
[16] https://iiif.io/news/2017/01/30/univ-basel-joins-iiifc/
[17] https://github.com/dasch-swiss/sipi
[18] https://iiif.io/news/2026/01/20/Bern-Vienna/
[19] https://bib.unibe.ch/iiif

6 Further Resources

This report does not cover implementation. The following entry points are recommended for institutions that wish to start or deepen their use of IIIF:

- Get started with IIIF: https://iiif.io/get-started/
- IIIF training, documentation and workshop materials: https://training.iiif.io/
- Finding IIIF Resources: https://guides.iiif.io/finding_resources/
- Awesome IIIF, a list of lists of awesome IIIF resources: https://iiif.github.io/awesome-iiif/
- IIIF Community and Technical Specification Groups: https://iiif.io/community/groups/
- IIIF Consortium: https://iiif.io/community/consortium/
- IIIF API Specifications: https://iiif.io/api/
- IIIF Cookbook of Presentation API recipes: https://iiif.io/api/cookbook/
- IIIF Presentation API Validator: https://presentation-validator.iiif.io/

7 Conclusion

Since the 2019 white paper [4], IIIF has become an established part of the Swiss digital heritage landscape. Twenty-three platforms meet the criteria of this report, operated by national and cantonal libraries, the Swiss Federal Archives, universities, research infrastructures, museums and foundations. Adoption has spread well beyond the manuscript and rare book portals that pioneered the framework in Switzerland, and the two Swiss members of IIIF-C, DaSCH and the University of Bern, anchor it in national research infrastructure and in university services.

The panorama also points to three areas where further work would bring the greatest benefit. First, several of the largest platforms still rely on version 2.x of the Image and Presentation APIs. Rather than stopping at version 3.0, platforms planning a migration could aim directly for the Presentation API 4.0, available as an alpha draft since June 2026, which brings, among other things, support for 3D content [2].[20] Beyond the two core specifications, the other IIIF APIs, such as Authorization Flow or Content Search, remain rarely implemented, the Swiss Federal Archives [8] and Books as Data being notable exceptions for Content Search. Second, a number of institutions expose images through the Image API without publishing Manifests, or publish Manifests that do not yet validate; closing that gap would make their holdings reusable in compatible IIIF clients. Third, discoverability remains limited: few platforms advertise a top-level Collection or appear in *Finding IIIF Resources*. The Change Discovery API was designed precisely to let aggregators find and synchronise IIIF resources at scale, yet it is still sparsely deployed across the global IIIF ecosystem.

Switzerland could well set an example here. e-codices was the first platform in the world to implement both version 2.0 of the Image API and version 2.0 of the Presentation API, upon their release in 2014. A similar pioneering role in adopting the Presentation API 4.0 or the Change Discovery API would be in keeping with that tradition.

Finally, IIIF remains a community effort as much as a set of specifications [10, 7]. Broader Swiss participation in the IIIF community groups and in IIIF-C would help ensure that the needs of Swiss institutions, including multilingual collections and archival holdings, are reflected in the future evolution of the framework. This report is a snapshot as of October 2026; later versions may update the panorama as platforms evolve.

[20] Demonstrators already show what such a migration can look like, for instance IIIF Studio, which upgrades Manifests between IIIF versions and validates them with inline issue annotations mapped onto JSON paths: https://iiif-studio.netlify.app/

Statement of Competing Interests

The author's main professional activity is at docuteam SA, a Swiss company providing services and software for digitisation, digital preservation and archival management, including IIIF-related work. The author previously worked at DaSCH and at the Swiss Federal Archives, both of which are discussed in this report. This report was written in the author's capacity as a Research Associate at the Walter Benjamin Kolleg, University of Bern, and was neither commissioned nor funded by docuteam.

To limit any bias, the criteria in Section 3 were applied uniformly, irrespective of the software or service provider behind a platform. The technical threshold was twofold: Manifests had to pass the IIIF Presentation API Validator, with those returning warnings accepted only when they open in a client external to the institution, and platforms included for their images alone had to serve requests following the Image API syntax and load in a deep zoom viewer external to the institution. The selection focuses on platforms run by, or associated with, public services and research institutions. Commercial offerings, including those of the author's employer, are not presented as platforms in their own right.

The author has also been an active member of the IIIF community, currently serving on the Coordinating Committee (CoCo), soon to be renamed the Community Committee, and having previously served for several years on the IIIF Technical Review Committee (TRC). The views expressed are his own.

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